

Buying AI Before the Safety Case Exists

Edition 1 in the Road Transport Group technology series, scoped to the Data, AI and Technology programme. Companion briefing: 'Autonomy, Clean Fuel and Digital Control Across Britain's Four Modes' (September 2026), written for the department as a whole.

Cycle: 18 September 2026 · Audience: Programme Manager, Data, AI and Technology · Horizon: to 2035

Read estimate: 5 min Executive Synthesis · 24 min full read

What you will learn

1. Why permission stopped being the constraint on all four modes in the same year
2. Which capacity reading moved against the department between May and September, and by how much
3. How the pathway choice got made without anyone taking the decision

Key takeaways

1. Rules landed in all four modes in 2026; the fleets they govern land in the 2030s
2. Battery supply is 31 GWh confirmed against roughly 130 GWh of 2035 demand, and one port was offered a 2039 grid connection
3. Four modes are separately solving the same unsolved problem, how to certify a system that decides for itself

Why This Matters Now

This programme is being held to dated obligations it cannot meet on its own. From 1 June 2026 new vehicle types need cyber and software-update approval. Applications to run driverless passenger services opened in May. Road charging starts in April 2028. Each date is real and each one is set outside this team.

The inputs are the problem. The duty that would require councils to supply digital traffic orders exists in law but has never been switched on, so the national service runs on whatever authorities choose to send. Most road data from connected vehicles sits with

manufacturers and is bought rather than owned. And the method for proving an AI driving system is safe enough has not been written yet, by anyone.

The one thing to take into the next meeting: this programme can be held to outcomes it has no instrument to compel the inputs for, and the fix is to say so in the business case rather than to absorb it.

Executive Synthesis

Which commitments in this portfolio depend on data or a method that somebody outside this team has to choose to provide?

The digital traffic order duty is uncommenced, connected vehicle data is bought from manufacturers on commercial terms, and the assurance method for machine-learned driving has no worked industrial example in the literature.

Four dated obligations now bear on this programme, and none of them was set here. New vehicle types placed on the GB market need cyber security and software update approval from 1 June 2026, brought in by statutory instrument in November 2025 ([the Vehicle Certification Agency](#), Nov 2025) under a UN regulation that requires a certified management system renewed every three years ([UN Regulation 155](#), Jan 2025). Applications to operate taxi, bus and private-hire style self-driving passenger services opened on 22 May 2026 ([DfT](#), May 2026). Electric vehicle excise duty starts in April 2028 on self-declared odometer readings ([HM Treasury](#), Jul 2026). Local highway authorities must submit evidence of professional development by 30 November 2026 or forfeit incentive funding, under a letter signed by this group's own director general ([DfT](#), Apr 2026). The dates are firm. What is not firm is anything this programme would need in order to meet them.

Start with the one the title names. The statutory standard for an automated vehicle is behavioural: it must drive to a level at least equivalent to a careful and competent human driver ([the Automated Vehicles Act 2024](#), May 2024), and the June consultation is explicit that "A careful and competent human driver represents a higher standard than an average driver." ([CP 1598](#), Jun 2026). That is a legal standard waiting for an engineering definition. The current peer-reviewed position is blunter: "Current automotive safety standards, whilst a good foundation for assuring the safety of E/E components, do not sufficiently cover the specifics of ANNs with regards to the creation

of a safety case.” ([Journal of Traffic and Transportation Engineering](#), Jun 2026), and the guidance that does exist lacks worked industrial examples. Meanwhile the approval route in practice is bespoke, negotiated case by case across three assessment areas and requiring a vehicle special order and extensive pre-engagement ([the Vehicle Certification Agency](#), May 2026). The profession that would eventually supply independent judgement is being built now: the assurance consortium stood up in June 2026 opened with a skills map, an ethics code and a mapping exercise to work out what information assessors even need access to ([Computer Weekly](#), Jun 2026).

The second problem is that the data this programme's benefits depend on belongs to other people. Section 93 of the Automated Vehicles Act would require English traffic authorities to supply traffic regulation order information digitally. The first commencement order, made in December 2025, brought in five sections and left section 93 out ([SI 2025/1339](#), Dec 2025), so the national digital traffic order service runs on voluntary supply and its own guidance sets out no duty, no commencement date and no deadline ([DfT](#), Sep 2025). Road length statistics now come from a commercial mapping product fed by street records that 175 highway authorities maintain “From 2026 onwards, the DfT will change to using data from OS MasterMap Highways products as the sole source of information for road length.” ([GeoPlace](#), Mar 2026). Parking data sits on a platform the department designed, divested, and can now only encourage authorities to join ([the National Parking Platform](#), Jul 2026). And most road data generated by connected vehicles is held by manufacturers, with public agencies as purchasers: “Despite the quantity of this data, much of it remains in private hands, and public agencies face significant costs to obtain them from automakers.” ([Future Transport-News](#), Jun 2026).

This programme can be held to outcomes it has no instrument to compel the inputs for, and the fix is to say so in the business case rather than to absorb it.

The contrast that makes this a choice rather than a fact of life is 200 miles away. The Dutch revised their intelligent transport regulation to oblige road authorities to supply traffic decisions, closures and roadworks as digitally processable data, in force from 21 December 2025, with 15 million euros of transition funding, a three-year front-runner group and a review point at the end of 2028 ([Digitaal Stelsel Mobiliteitsdata](#), Nov 2025). The obligation, the money and the runway were legislated together. England has the obligation drafted and uncommenced, 30 million pounds going to a pre-selected set of

authorities for digital twin trials ([DfT](#), Jul 2026), and no review point, because there is nothing yet to review. The Netherlands bought less and got more, because it bought a duty.

The connected vehicle workstream is the part of this remit where the department is furthest forward and the commitment is least quantified. A programme organised into seven use case groups is at the point where officials say they will soon be able to discuss funding and pilots, with the smart streets manual to be rewritten as the digital equivalent of the road design manual ([Highways Magazine](#), Mar 2026), on an argument that the current market is closed and vendor-locked and that the state's job is to force it open ([Highways News](#), May 2026). That is the right diagnosis. The open question is what the UK will be interoperable with. Europe has roughly 5,900 roadside units across 32,700 km and national access point deadlines already passed ([the European Commission](#), Apr 2026), the Data Act has settled that vehicle data belongs to the user rather than the manufacturer “The right of users to access the data generated by the use of the product and to designate third parties to receive them constitutes the core feature of the new regime.” ([Garrigues](#), Nov 2025), and the leading continental model is a decentralised data space in which manufacturers keep contractual sovereignty over terms of use ([the Mobility Data Space](#), Feb 2026). None of those choices is the UK's to make, and all of them constrain what a British specification can specify.

Where this analysis could be wrong

Uncommenced is not the same as abandoned. Section 93 may be commenced at any time, and departments routinely sequence commencement to let a service mature before a duty bites. A reading that treats the gap as neglect would be wrong. The narrower claim, and the one this brief makes, is that a programme cannot plan on an obligation that has no commencement date, and that the Dutch instrument shows the alternative was available. The thesis weakens the moment a commencement order naming section 93 is laid.

The assurance gap may close faster than the literature suggests. Academic reviews lag practice, and a developer with a large validated fleet may already hold a method that works even if nobody has published it. The department is also generating exactly that evidence through permitted deployment ([DfT](#), May 2026). This brief does not claim the method is impossible; it claims the method is not yet public, not yet standardised and not yet something a contract can reference by number, which is a different and more practical problem.

Parts of this base are thinner than a source count suggests. The claim that most connected vehicle data sits in private hands rests on one trade source that offers no quantified split ([Future Transport-News](#), Jun 2026), and is carried here as direction rather than magnitude. There is no dated UK decision on spectrum or roadside infrastructure inside the recency window at any tier, so the European deployment figures ([the European Commission](#), Apr 2026) are used as a benchmark and not as a UK position. And no authoritative dated account of a cyber incident against a UK local authority traffic control system could be verified, so the reference incident used here is an automotive manufacturer ([Hansard](#), Oct 2025), which is adjacent rather than identical.

The decisions that cannot be deferred this cycle

1. **Write the uncommenced duty into the risk register, by name.** Section 93 is the single assumption most likely to be inherited silently by a business case, because it exists in statute and reads as settled.
2. **Ask for the assurance clause before the procurement, not during it.** The department has committed to guidance on data and ownership in commercial arrangements, and the consortium is still mapping what assessors need to see; a clause drafted after award cannot be negotiated.

3. **Decide what the UK will be interoperable with.** European access points, data-space governance and vehicle data rights are already fixed, and a British specification that ignores them will be reconciled later at higher cost.
4. **Separate the dates you must meet from the inputs you cannot compel.** Four obligations are dated and firm; at least three of the inputs they need are voluntary, commercial or unwritten, and only this programme is positioned to say which is which.

Each is developed below, with a decision posture, in the four Strategic Implications.

Audience Snapshots

Four lenses on the same evidence base. Each card surfaces the one question this cycle puts to that reader.

BUSINESS CASE & BENEFITS

The dates are firm and several of the inputs behind them are voluntary

The shift: Cyber and software-update approval binds new vehicle types from 1 June 2026 ([the Vehicle Certification Agency](#), Nov 2025), passenger service applications opened in May ([DfT](#), May 2026) and road charging starts in April 2028 ([HM Treasury](#), Jul 2026), while the duty that would compel digital traffic order supply is uncommenced ([SI 2025/1339](#), Dec 2025).

The question to brief: Which benefits in the current case depend on an input we cannot require anyone to provide, and are they labelled as such?

DATA & INTEROPERABILITY

The department is building a catalogue for data it does not hold

The shift: The action plan commits to a marketplace, an ontology and open standards ([DfT](#), Mar 2026), while street reference data is maintained by 175 authorities ([GeoPlace](#), Mar 2026), parking sits on a divested platform ([the National Parking Platform](#), Jul 2026), and connected vehicle data is bought from manufacturers ([Future Transport-News](#), Jun 2026).

The question to brief: For each dataset this programme depends on, who holds it, under what obligation, and what happens if they stop?

ASSURANCE & SAFETY CASE

A legal standard is in force and its engineering definition is not written

The shift: The statutory test is equivalence with a careful and competent driver ([the Automated Vehicles Act 2024](#), May 2024) ([CP 1598](#), Jun 2026), the peer-reviewed position is that automotive standards do not cover neural network safety cases ([Journal of Traffic and Transportation Engineering](#), Jun 2026), and approval today is a negotiated case-by-case assessment ([the Vehicle Certification Agency](#), May 2026).

The question to brief: If a safety case arrived this week, what would we measure it against, and who would sign?

SUPPLIER MARKET & PROCUREMENT

The obligations are moving into the supply chain faster than the clauses are

The shift: The cyber resilience bill pulls managed service providers and critical suppliers into scope ([the House of Commons Library](#), May 2026), European risk work recommends powers to exclude high-risk suppliers ([the NIS Cooperation Group](#), Jan 2026), and the assurance profession that would audit any of this began standing up in June 2026 ([Computer Weekly](#), Jun 2026).

The question to brief: Do our current contracts give us the access an assessor would need, and if not, when is the next point we can change them?

Themes

The cycle's signals are organised into six themes, ranked by impact on near-term decisions.

Immediate: changes the near-term plan, the structure or the proposition. **Near-Term:** changes position over the next twelve months. **Longer-Range:** a multi-year factor to track and revisit each cycle.

1. Assuring driving decisions the programme cannot yet specify

IMMEDIATE

The statutory safety standard for an automated vehicle is behavioural rather than technical, and that is deliberate: Parliament chose a principles document over a specification because the behaviour cannot be enumerated in statute ([the Automated Vehicles Act 2024](#), May 2024). The consequence lands here. A programme that buys, pilots or contracts for automated driving has to judge evidence against a standard whose engineering definition does not yet exist, using an assurance profession that is currently being assembled.

Every date below was set outside this programme

Dec 2025	●	Dutch duty to supply digital traffic data comes into force
Dec 2025	●	First UK commencement order omits the equivalent duty
May 2026	●	Applications open to run self-driving passenger services
Jun 2026	●	Vehicle cyber and software-update approval becomes mandatory
Nov 2026	●	Authorities must evidence highways skills or lose incentive funding
Late 2027	●	Full automated vehicles regime targeted for implementation
Apr 2028	●	Electric vehicle excise duty starts, on odometer readings

Dates as printed by the instrument that sets them. The red marker is the one obligation on this list that was drafted for England and then left switched off.

- The June 2026 consultation puts the bar above the average driver and says so directly: “A careful and competent human driver represents a higher standard than an average driver.” ([CP 1598](#), Jun 2026). The standard is to be met behaviourally, with evidence from simulation, track and real-world testing rather than one specified test.
- The peer-reviewed position on method is unambiguous: “Current automotive safety standards, whilst a good foundation for assuring the safety of E/E components, do not sufficiently cover the specifics of ANNs with regards to the creation of a safety case.” ([Journal of Traffic and Transportation Engineering](#), Jun 2026). Published guidance for machine learning exist but lack fully worked industrial, preferably automotive, examples.
- The department opened the door in May and said so plainly: “Passengers could book taxi and bus-style self-driving vehicles later this year, as applications open today (22 May 2026) for operators to run cars across Great Britain.” ([DfT](#), May 2026). Services could be bookable by the public later in the year, subject to safety approval, cyber and security assessment and local transport authority consent.
- In practice approval is negotiated rather than certified. Applications are assessed across automated driving system capability, cyber security and software updating, and operational management, and need a vehicle special order, a vehicle listing and substantial pre-engagement before submission ([the Vehicle Certification Agency](#), May 2026).
- There is a standard a contract can cite by number. It covers the operational safety case and safety management system for trials, defining the safety case as a structured argument supported by evidence that risks are reduced as low as reasonably practicable ([PAS 1881:2026](#), Mar 2026). It governs trials, not authorisation.
- The independent judgement this eventually needs is a year away at best. The assurance consortium launched in June 2026 with a skills and competencies map, a professional ethics code, and a mapping of what information assurance providers need in order to assess a system at all ([Computer Weekly](#), Jun 2026).

Early indicators

- **WEAK SIGNAL** **The UK has chosen assurance over statute, which pushes the obligation into guidance.** The national approach rests on a portfolio of assurance techniques, sector guidance and a roadmap to third-party assurance, with existing regulators applying the principles in their own domains rather than a horizontal AI law ([the Alan Turing Institute](#), Jan 2026). A programme therefore inherits its obligations from expectation and guidance, which are harder to point at in a business case than a statutory duty.
- **WEAK SIGNAL** **Liability is allocated before the method to test it exists.** The Act creates two liability-bearing entities, the authorised self-driving entity and the no-user-in-charge operator, so insurers expect someone to recover against where no human is liable ([Insurance Business UK](#), Feb 2026). Pricing that risk depends on secondary legislation still moving through 2026.

Counter-argument

A developer running a large validated fleet may already hold a workable method that simply has not been published, and the department is generating exactly this evidence through permitted deployment. The claim here is deliberately narrower than saying the method is impossible: it is that the method is not public, not standardised, and not citable by number in a contract, which is what a programme actually needs. The thesis weakens the moment any regulator or developer publishes a quantified method the others adopt.

Decision link: What this programme measures a supplier's safety case against, and who in the department is competent to sign it off, before the statement of safety principles is finalised.

2. The road data layer the department does not own

IMMEDIATE

The department has committed to a catalogue, an ontology and open standards for transport data ([DfT](#), Mar 2026). What it has not acquired is the right to require anyone to fill them. The duty that would compel English traffic authorities to supply traffic regulation order information digitally sits in the Automated Vehicles Act and has never been switched on, and the practical consequences of that omission run through every benefit this programme is likely to claim.

Money put into local authority data capability, and what it bought

England, digital twin trials
DfT, July 2026

30 million pounds
Pre-selected authorities. No duty to supply data.

Netherlands, transition funding
Digitaal Stelsel Mobiliteitsdata, Nov 2025

15 million euros
All decentralised authorities. Duty in force 21 Dec 2025.

Bars are drawn to the numeric amounts. The currencies are not converted, because the comparison being made is not of value but of what each instrument obliged anyone to do.

England has 175 highway authorities maintaining the street records that now determine road length statistics and, through them, funding.

- The first commencement order under the Act, made in December 2025 and in force from January 2026, brought in five sections and left out section 93, the digital traffic order duty ([SI 2025/1339](#), Dec 2025). Nothing in the public record sets a date for it.
- The service built for that duty runs anyway. Its own guidance describes publication by authorities or their solution providers and sets out no duty, no commencement date and no deadline ([DfT](#), Sep 2025), and the underlying data model is still described as candidate and experimental.
- Where the department does have leverage it is financial rather than legal. Incentive funding is withheld entirely without a published transparency report, with publication carrying 50% of the incentive, spend verification 25%, and asset management policy 12.5%, and a skills evidence submission due by 30 November 2026 ([DfT](#), Apr 2026).
- Reference data is now a funding control. From 2026 “From 2026 onwards, the DfT will change to using data from OS MasterMap Highways products as the sole source of information for road length.” ([GeoPlace](#), Mar 2026), which means the street records maintained monthly by 175 highway authorities determine how much money those same authorities receive.
- The parking layer has already been divested. The platform the department designed is now an independent not-for-profit, and the department's lever is a ministerial letter encouraging authorities to consider joining, expressly leaving contract decisions to them ([the National Parking Platform](#), Jul 2026).

Early indicators

- **WEAK SIGNAL** **Capability is being seeded in a chosen few rather than built across the sector.** Thirty million pounds is available for integrated transport digital twin trials, restricted to pre-selected authorities rather than open competition ([DfT](#), Jul 2026). That is a reasonable way to start and an admission that the capability to supply a national data layer does not currently exist across 175 authorities.
- **WEAK SIGNAL** **The Netherlands legislated the duty, the money and the runway together.** The revised Dutch regulation obliges authorities to supply traffic decisions, closures and roadworks in digitally processable form from 21 December 2025, with 15 million euros of transition funding, a three-year front-runner group and a review at the end of 2028: in Dutch, "In de nieuwe Europese regels moeten deze maatregelen niet alleen worden vastgelegd, maar ook digitaal verwerkbaar worden aangeleverd.", which reads in English as "Under the new European rules these measures must not only be recorded, but also supplied in digitally processable form" ([Digitaal Stelsel Mobiliteitsdata](#), Nov 2025). England has the duty drafted and dormant.

Counter-argument

Uncommenced is not abandoned. Departments routinely delay commencement to let a service mature, and section 93 could be switched on at any time, at which point this theme becomes a transition question rather than a gap. That is the strongest reading against this argument and it may well be right. What a programme cannot do is plan on it: a duty with no commencement date cannot carry a benefit in a business case. The thesis weakens the moment a commencement order naming section 93 is laid.

Decision link: Whether any benefit in the current portfolio depends on data supply that is voluntary, and whether the business case says so.

3. Connected vehicle services, where the standard is open and the data is not

NEAR-TERM

This is the part of the remit where the department is furthest forward and the commitment is least quantified. A connected vehicle services programme has moved from a conversation opened in October 2025 ([Highways News](#), Oct 2025) to the point where officials expect to discuss funding and pilots ([Highways Magazine](#), Mar 2026). The diagnosis behind it is sound: the current market is closed and vendor-locked, and the state's role is to force it open ([Highways News](#), May 2026). The unanswered question is what the result will be interoperable with.

- It organises services into seven use case groups spanning safety and emergency, traffic management, vehicle capability, in-vehicle experience, maintenance, support for authorities, and fleet and logistics, and commits to rewriting the smart streets manual as the digital equivalent of the road design manual ([Highways Magazine](#), Mar 2026). No funding figure and no pilot location has been published.
- The department's own data plan carries the procurement half of this, committing to guidance on data sharing and ownership in commercial arrangements for procuring products and services ([DfT](#), Mar 2026). That guidance does not yet exist.
- Europe has already built at the scale the UK is discussing: roughly 5,900 roadside units covering 32,700 km of the trans-European network, with national access point deadlines of December 2025 and 2026 and named harmonising standards ([the European Commission](#), Apr 2026).
- Who owns the data has been decided elsewhere, and not in the manufacturer's favour. Under the European Data Act "The right of users to access the data generated by the use of the product and to designate third parties to receive them constitutes the core feature of the new regime." ([Garrigues](#), Nov 2025), with the contested boundary now between readily available data and proprietary inferred data such as driving-style scores.
- The access route is being tightened rather than opened. A March 2026 delegated regulation lets manufacturers authenticate diagnostic tools, log access and suspend it during security incidents, while preserving independent operators' right of access, on the principle that security may govern how data is reached but never who may reach it ([Delegated Regulation C\(2026\) 1811](#), Mar 2026).

Early indicators

- **WEAK SIGNAL** **The leading continental model keeps sovereignty with the manufacturer.** The German mobility data space and the European road safety data consortium have agreed to exchange sensor-detected safety events in near real time through a decentralised infrastructure governed by a multi-party contract in German, "Informationen über diese Ereignisse werden sensorbasiert erkannt und in nahezu Echtzeit mit relevanten Akteuren über den MDS zur Aufbereitung von Warnungen geteilt.", which reads in English as "Information about these events is detected by sensors and shared in near real time with relevant actors through the MDS so that warnings can be prepared" ([the Mobility Data Space](#), Feb 2026). The design bet is that manufacturers will only supply data if they keep enforceable control of the terms, which is the opposite of a central pool.
- **WEAK SIGNAL** **A national data system is the layer above, and the Dutch are already there.** The Netherlands runs its connected-vehicle work under a national digital mobility data system positioned as the delivery vehicle for European legal obligations rather than a separate domestic project ([the Dutch Ministry of Infrastructure and Water Management](#), Jan 2026), and its live question is whether municipalities can carry the implementation load. That is the same question England has not yet reached.

Counter-argument

Moving slowly here may be correct. Committing to a radio technology or a message set too early is how national programmes strand assets, and the department's stated approach, settle what services are needed before choosing the technology, is a defensible sequence rather than a delay. The narrower claim is that interoperability targets are not a technology choice and can be settled now, and that every month they are not, suppliers build to something else. The thesis weakens if the programme publishes named standards alongside its first pilots.

Decision link: Which European instruments and standards the UK will be interoperable with, stated before the first pilot is funded rather than after.

4. Cyber and positioning obligations set outside the programme

NEAR-TERM

Two dependency layers under everything above are governed by instruments this programme does not control and cannot influence on its own timetable. Vehicle cyber security is now a type approval matter with a hard UK date. Positioning and timing resilience is a national infrastructure programme run from another department. Both are moving in the programme's favour, and both set constraints it has to design around rather than decide.

- The date is fixed and close. A statutory instrument brought the UN cyber security and software update regulations into GB type approval in November 2025, and “The first mandatory implementation date for new types of complete and base vehicles is set for 1 June 2026.” ([the Vehicle Certification Agency](#), Nov 2025). Anything specified after that can assume both approvals as a baseline.
- The underlying obligation is organisational, not a test. A certified cyber security management system covering development, production and post-production, valid three years, with monitoring for new threats after registration and annual reporting to the approval authority ([UN Regulation 155](#), Jan 2025). That is a standing obligation on a supplier and therefore a standing contract term.
- The scope is widening into the supply chain. The cyber resilience bill extends the existing regime to managed service providers and critical suppliers to regulated organisations, and transport is already a regulated sector with the department as competent authority ([the House of Commons Library](#), May 2026). The compliance question moves from the estate to the contracts.
- European risk work has gone further and named the remedy. Its top scenario is a hostile state pressuring a manufacturer to implement hidden malicious hardware or software, and its recommendation is a common basis for assessing critical suppliers plus national powers to

restrict or exclude high-risk ones ([the NIS Cooperation Group](#), Jan 2026), on the view that type approval cannot stop a supplier with legitimate privileged access.

- The security guidance that actually fits roadside estate is about connectivity, not endpoints. Eight principles for operational technology, agreed with six partner agencies, end with an isolation plan, on the basis that in these environments an intrusion can cause physical harm ([the National Cyber Security Centre](#), Jan 2026). Traffic signals, tunnel control and variable message signs are operational technology in exactly that sense.
- Positioning resilience is funded and sits elsewhere: 155 million pounds across terrestrial long-range navigation, a national timing centre and interference monitoring ([DSIT](#), Nov 2025). Road appears only indirectly, so the practical implication is to leave interface room rather than to wait.

Early indicators

- **WEAK SIGNAL** **Road charging has already been designed away from satellite positioning.** Electric vehicle excise duty starts in April 2028 on self-declared odometer readings, with connected vehicle data as an opt-in convenience and new offences for odometer tampering ([HM Treasury](#), Jul 2026). The assurance problem for road charging is therefore odometer and in-vehicle data integrity, which is exactly what the two UN regulations govern, and not satellite spoofing.
- **WEAK SIGNAL** **Jamming at scale has so far been survivable where redundancy was designed in.** Finland reports interference rising through spring 2026 and constant in aviation, while at ground level disruption largely does not appear, because the effect attenuates quickly against terrain, trees and buildings, and the timing layer held for a separate reason, in Finnish, “Suomessa matkaviestinverkoissa on omat varmennetut synkronointijärjestelyt, joita GNSS-signaali täydentää ja tämän vuoksi GNSS-häirintä ei meillä ole vaikuttanut matkaviestinverkkojen toimintaan”, which reads in English as “In Finland the mobile networks have their own assured synchronisation arrangements, which the GNSS signal supplements, and for this reason GNSS jamming has not affected the operation of mobile networks here” ([Traficom](#), Apr 2026). Resilience turned out to be an architecture decision taken years earlier.

Counter-argument

It is reasonable to argue this theme is somebody else's problem, and in the narrow sense it is: the approval regime is the certification agency's, the resilience programme is another department's, and neither needs this programme's agreement. The reason it belongs here is procurement timing. Both create obligations that bind through contracts this programme lets, and contracts are the slowest thing to change. The thesis weakens if standard departmental terms are updated to carry the management system, supplier access and isolation requirements as a matter of course.

Decision link: Whether current and imminent contracts carry the cyber management system obligation, the assessor access rights and an isolation requirement, given that none of these is optional after award.

Strategic Implications

Four moves turn this cycle's evidence into the next business case. Two are decisions, one is preparation that can start immediately, and one is a standing watch on an instrument somebody else controls.

SI 1: Name the uncommenced duty as an assumption, in writing

Section 93 of the Automated Vehicles Act would require English traffic authorities to supply traffic regulation order data digitally. The December 2025 commencement order left it out ([SI 2025/1339](#), Dec 2025), and the service that would receive that data states no duty and no deadline ([DfT](#), Sep 2025). A benefit that assumes national digital traffic order coverage is therefore resting on voluntary supply, and it will read as settled to anyone who sees the statute without checking the commencement order. This is the assumption most likely to be inherited silently.

Action: Add the uncommenced status of section 93 to the programme risk register by name and section number, with the commencement order cited, and state in the next business case which benefits depend on it.

DECIDE

Draws on Theme 2

SI 2: Get the assurance and access clauses drafted before the next procurement

Three obligations converge on the contract rather than on the system. The safety case has no citable method yet ([Journal of Traffic and Transportation Engineering](#), Jun 2026), the assurance profession is still mapping what information assessors need ([Computer Weekly](#), Jun 2026), and the cyber regime is extending to critical suppliers and managed service providers ([the House of Commons Library](#), May 2026) while the vehicle regulation imposes a standing management system obligation ([UN Regulation 155](#), Jan 2025). The department has committed to guidance on data sharing and ownership in procurement ([DfT](#), Mar 2026) but has not published it. A clause that does not exist at award cannot be negotiated afterwards.

Action: Commission model clauses covering assessor access to system information, the cyber security management system obligation and an isolation requirement, and hold them ready for the next procurement rather than waiting for central guidance.

DECIDE

Draws on Themes 1 and 4

SI 3: State what the connected vehicle programme will be interoperable with

It is at the funding and pilots stage with seven use case groups and no published standards list ([Highways Magazine](#), Mar 2026). Meanwhile Europe has 5,900 roadside units and passed access point deadlines ([the European Commission](#), Apr 2026), vehicle data rights are settled in the user's favour ([Garrigues](#), Nov 2025), and the leading continental architecture keeps contractual sovereignty with the manufacturer ([the Mobility Data Space](#), Feb 2026). None of that is the UK's to decide, and all of it constrains what a British specification can require. Naming the targets is not the same as choosing a radio technology, and can be done now.

Action: Publish the interoperability targets, the European instruments and standards it intends to work with, alongside the first pilot announcement rather than after it.

PREPARE

Draws on Theme 3

SI 4: Watch the commencement orders, not the Act

Two things this programme depends on will change by statutory instrument rather than by announcement: the commencement of section 93, and the secondary legislation completing the automated vehicles regime, which is running through 2026 towards implementation targeted for late 2027 ([Insurance Business UK](#), Feb 2026). Neither will be trailed in a way a delivery team would notice, and both change what can be committed to in a business case. The finalisation of the statement of safety principles ([CP 1598](#), Jun 2026) is the third.

Action: Put a standing monthly check on new commencement orders under the Act and on the safety principles outcome, owned by a named person, so the programme learns about a change in its own obligations from the instrument rather than from a supplier.

MONITOR

Draws on Themes 1 and 2

Scenario Matrix

The two axes are the two things this cycle says are genuinely open for this programme. The horizontal axis is whether the inputs it depends on become compellable, through commencement, standards or contract. The vertical axis is whether a citable assurance method appears. The dated obligations are assumed in all four quadrants, because they are already fixed.

WHETHER THE INPUTS BECOME COMPELLABLE

A programme that can commit

Section 93 is commenced with funding and a runway, model clauses land ahead of the next procurement, and one regulator or developer publishes a quantified assurance method that others adopt. The programme can then write benefits it can actually defend, because both the data supply and the acceptance test are things it can point at. This is the scenario the current portfolio is implicitly written for, and it requires decisions that have not been taken.

Early indicators: A commencement order naming section 93; publication of the department's procurement data guidance; any published quantified method for demonstrating the statutory safety standard

Assured but unevidenced

The assurance question resolves, through the consortium or through a developer publishing a method, but the data layer stays voluntary and commercial. The programme can then judge a safety case and still cannot guarantee national coverage of the traffic regulation data those systems need to obey. Deployment becomes geographically patchy along the boundary of which authorities chose to supply, which is the least defensible pattern to explain publicly.

Early indicators: A published assurance method with no matching commencement order; digital traffic order coverage plateauing below full national coverage; deployments clustering in supplying authorities

Data without a test

Commencement and contract terms fix the inputs, but the acceptance question stays unresolved. The programme holds good data and still has no defensible basis on which to say yes or no to a supplier's safety case, so decisions concentrate on

METHOD ABSENT, INPUTS COMPELLABLE **METHOD ABSENT, INPUTS STAY VOLUNTARY**

certification agency's case-by-case assessment. Workable, slow, and highly dependent on a small number of individuals.

Early indicators: Section 93 commenced; continued absence of a citable method; growth in bespoke vehicle special orders rather than a standard route

Held to dates, given neither

Nothing moves on either axis and the dated obligations arrive anyway. The programme is accountable for outcomes whose inputs are voluntary and whose acceptance test is unwritten, which is the position it occupies today.

rules this out, and that is why the first recommendation is to write the dependency down rather than to fix it, because writing it down is the part this programme controls.

Early indicators: No commencement order within twelve months; procurement guidance still unpublished; assurance consortium still on its first-year skills map at the 2027 business case

What We Are Not Planning For

POSITIONING

We are not planning for satellite positioning integrity to be the binding constraint on road charging

Electric vehicle excise duty starts in April 2028 on self-declared odometer readings, with connected vehicle data as an opt-in convenience and new offences for odometer tampering ([HM Treasury](#), Jul 2026). The design deliberately avoids a location-based system, so the integrity problem is the odometer and the in-vehicle data path, which the vehicle cyber and software update regulations already govern ([UN Regulation 155](#), Jan 2025). We plan on that basis and not on a positioning-dependent charging scheme.

↺ **Reinstated if** a distance or location-based charging option is reopened, or the optional connectivity route becomes the default assessment basis.

MARKET STRUCTURE

We are not planning for the department to hold connected vehicle data directly

Most road data generated by connected vehicles sits with manufacturers and brokers, with public agencies as purchasers ([Future Transport-News](#), Jun 2026), European law has settled access rights in favour of the user rather than creating a public entitlement ([Garrigues](#), Nov 2025), and the leading continental architecture keeps contractual sovereignty with the manufacturer ([the Mobility Data Space](#), Feb 2026). We plan to be a buyer and a standards-setter, not an owner.

↺ **Reinstated if** a UK access right for road authorities is legislated, or the connected vehicle framework publishes a public data entitlement rather than an interoperability standard.

AUTONOMY AT SCALE

We are not planning for self-driving passenger services to be a national market inside this horizon

Applications opened in May 2026 ([DfT](#), May 2026) but approval remains a negotiated case-by-case assessment requiring a vehicle special order, a vehicle listing and pre-engagement ([the Vehicle Certification Agency](#), May 2026), and the statutory safety principles are still out for consultation ([CP 1598](#), Jun 2026). We model permitted city-scale services through the late 2020s and treat national coverage as a question for the 2030s.

↻ **Reinstated if** permits are granted at a rate implying multi-city coverage, or a standard authorisation route replaces the vehicle special order.

Questions For The Next Strategy Meeting

Five questions this cycle's evidence should put on the agenda.

- 01 Which benefits in our current portfolio depend on section 93 being commenced, and does the business case say that it has not been ([SI 2025/1339](#), Dec 2025) ([DfT](#), Sep 2025)?
- 02 If a supplier submitted an automated driving safety case this week, what would we measure it against, and who here would sign ([CP 1598](#), Jun 2026) ([Journal of Traffic and Transportation Engineering](#), Jun 2026)?
- 03 Do our existing contracts give an assessor the access they would need, given that the body defining that need only began work in June 2026 ([Computer Weekly](#), Jun 2026) ([the House of Commons Library](#), May 2026)?
- 04 The Netherlands legislated the duty, the funding and the runway together ([Digitaal Stelsel Mobiliteitsdata](#), Nov 2025) and we have funded trials in pre-selected authorities ([DfT](#), Jul 2026). Which of those are we actually doing?

- 05 What are we telling suppliers our connected vehicle work will be interoperable with, before the first pilot is funded ([Highways Magazine](#), Mar 2026) ([the European Commission](#), Apr 2026)?

Source Confidence Register

This briefing draws on 35 verified sources, gathered under a declared twelve-month window (publications from September 2025 onward), with 3 structural anchors outside it. 4 are in a language other than English and were read in the original, because on this topic the translated version arrives late and loses the numbers.

Source tiers: **Tier 1**, governments, parliaments, regulators, courts and intergovernmental bodies. **Tier 2**, national audit offices, think-tanks, academic institutes and major professional firms. **Tier 3**, quality journalism and specialist trade press. **Tier 4**, vendor and practitioner sources, used only as directional corroboration. This cycle uses no Tier 4 source.

Theme 1: Assuring driving decisions the programme cannot yet specify

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Department for Transport / Centre for Connected and Autonomous Vehicles (CP 1598)	Tier 1	Jun 2026	The consultation sets the benchmark above the average driver, stating that a careful and competent human driver is a higher standard than an average driver, and says the standard is to be met behaviourally, with evidence drawn from simulation, track testing and real-world testing rather than from a single specified test.
Vehicle Certification Agency (executive agency of the Department for Transport)	Tier 1	May 2026	Applications to the VCA are assessed across three areas, automated driving system capability, cyber security and software updating, and operational management, with deployments requiring a Vehicle Special Order and a Vehicle Listing, significant pre-engagement with VCA, DVSA and CCAV before submission, and separate automated passenger service permit compliance where a passenger service is involved.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Department for Transport and Centre for Connected and Autonomous Vehicles (GOV.UK)	Tier 1	May 2026	Applications opened on 22 May 2026 for operators to run taxi, bus and private-hire style self-driving passenger services across Great Britain, with services potentially bookable by the public later in 2026, subject to government safety approvals, cyber and security assessment, and local transport authority consent.
The National Archives / legislation.gov.uk (UK Parliament)	Tier 1	May 2024	Section 1 sets a self-driving test requiring a vehicle to travel autonomously safely and legally, and section 2 requires the Secretary of State to publish a statement of safety principles framed to secure that authorised automated vehicles achieve a level of safety equivalent to, or higher than, that of careful and competent human drivers, and that road safety in Great Britain is better than it would otherwise be.
Journal of Traffic and Transportation Engineering (English Edition), Elsevier	Tier 2	Jun 2026	The review finds that existing automotive safety standards do not adequately cover neural network elements for the purpose of building a safety case, and that although machine-learning published guidance now exists it lacks fully worked industrial, preferably automotive, examples.
BSI Standards Limited (preview pages via ANSI Webstore)	Tier 2	Mar 2026	The specification sets requirements for operational safety cases and the supporting safety management system for automated vehicle tests and trials in Great Britain, defining a safety case as a structured argument supported by a body of evidence showing risks are identified, managed and reduced to as low as reasonably practicable, and covering route assessment, vehicle modification, incident response and override of the automated system.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
The Alan Turing Institute	Tier 2	Jan 2026	The profile sets out that the UK relies on a non-statutory, assurance-led approach built on the portfolio of AI Assurance Techniques, sector guidance and the Roadmap to Trusted Third-Party AI Assurance, with existing sector regulators operationalising the AI principles in their own domains rather than a horizontal AI statute.
Computer Weekly (TechTarget)	Tier 3	Jun 2026	DSIT and BCS launched an AI Assurance Stakeholder Consortium whose first-year work is a skills and competencies map, a professional ethics code for assurance practitioners, and mapping the information and data access that assurance providers need in order to assess AI systems properly.
Insurance Business UK (Key Media)	Tier 3	Feb 2026	The Automated Vehicles Act creates two new liability-bearing entities, the authorised self-driving entity, typically the manufacturer, and the no-user-in-charge operator, typically the service provider, so that where there is no human liability insurers expect a third party to recover against, and liability allocation differs between user-in-charge and no-user-in-charge modes.

Theme 2: The road data layer the department does not own

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Department for Transport (GOV.UK)	Tier 1	Jul 2026	The department has made 30 million pounds of grant funding available to pre-selected local transport authorities in England to run integrated transport digital twin trials in support of the Better Connected strategy, with eligibility restricted to authorities already chosen rather than open competition.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Department for Transport (GOV.UK)	Tier 1	Apr 2026	The department ties local highway incentive funding to published data and evidence: a highways maintenance transparency report must be published or all incentive funding is withheld, publication carries 50% of incentive funding, spend verification 25%, publication of an asset management policy and strategy reviewed within the past 24 months 12.5%, and by 30 November 2026 authorities must submit evidence that their highways maintenance team has undertaken learning or professional development in the preceding 12 months.
The National Archives / legislation.gov.uk (UK Statutory Instruments)	Tier 1	Dec 2025	The first commencement order under the Automated Vehicles Act 2024, made 15 December 2025 and in force 1 January 2026, brings in only sections 55 and 56 fully and sections 78, 88 and 89 for regulation-making purposes, and does not commence section 93, the provision that would require English traffic authorities to supply traffic regulation order information to the Secretary of State in digital form.
Digitaal Stelsel Mobiliteitsdata, Ministerie van Infrastructuur en Waterstaat (in Dutch)	Tier 1	Nov 2025	The revised Dutch ITS regulation came into force on 21 December 2025 and obliges road authorities to supply traffic decisions, road closures and roadworks as digitally processable data, with no compulsory additional investment required before 2028, 15 million euros of transition funding for decentralised authorities, a three-year front-runner group working on practical implementation, and new arrangements to be settled at the end of 2028 on the basis of experience.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Department for Transport (GOV.UK)	Tier 1	Sep 2025	The official guidance states that digital traffic regulation orders are published to the central service by traffic regulation authorities or their digital solution providers, and it sets out no statutory duty, no commencement date and no compliance deadline for authorities.
National Parking Platform	Tier 2	Jul 2026	The Roads and Buses Minister has written to local authorities in England encouraging them to consider joining the National Parking Platform, an open platform originally designed and developed by the department and now operated independently as a not-for-profit, with the letter expressly acknowledging that parking payment contract decisions remain a matter for individual authorities.
GeoPlace LLP	Tier 2	Mar 2026	From 2026 the department will use Ordnance Survey MasterMap Highways products as the sole source of road length information, replacing the four-yearly return that underpins national road length statistics, so the local street gazetteer records that 175 highway authorities in England and Wales upload monthly to the National Street Gazetteer hub now determine those authorities' funding positions.
Future Transport-News	Tier 3	Jun 2026	Most of the road infrastructure data generated by connected vehicles sits with vehicle manufacturers and commercial data brokers rather than public agencies, and transport authorities must pay significant sums to obtain it, with the alternatives being public fleet telematics or partnerships with automated vehicle operators, both of which limit geographic scope and consistency.

Theme 3: Connected vehicle services, where the standard is open and the data is not

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
European Commission (Staff Working Document SWD(2026) 117 final)	Tier 1	Apr 2026	The Commission reports approximately 5,900 C-ITS roadside units deployed covering 32,700 km of the trans-European transport network, that Day-1 and Day-1.5 services rest on the exchange of secured and trusted messages, that member states face national access point data availability deadlines of 31 December 2025 and 2026 with DATEX II and NeTEx as the harmonising standards, and reported benefits including travel time reductions up to 39% and crash reductions up to 50%.
Department for Transport	Tier 1	Mar 2026	The plan commits the department to a single trusted catalogue for transport data in the Transport Data Marketplace, a Transport Data Ontology developed with the National Digital Twin Programme and published for open use, an open-by-default and open-standards principle, a web portal for local authorities to submit data, and guidance on data sharing and ownership in commercial arrangements for procuring products and services.
European Commission (Delegated Regulation C(2026) 1811)	Tier 1	Mar 2026	The regulation allows vehicle manufacturers to authenticate diagnostic tools, log access attempts and temporarily suspend access during security incidents, while preserving independent operators' unrestricted access to on-board diagnostics data, clarifying information requirements for battery and driver assistance repair, permitting data access routes other than the physical port, and setting a lead time before reprogramming requirements apply.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Ministerie van Infrastructuur en Waterstaat (Rijksoverheid) <i>(in Dutch)</i>	Tier 1	Jan 2026	The minister informs the Dutch parliament on the commitment to and progress of the Digitaal Stelsel Mobiliteitsdata, the national digital mobility data system, setting it against the European ITS Directive obligation to digitalise specified mobility data, and transmits a policy memorandum and a feasibility assessment of implementation by local authorities.
Mobility Data Space and Data for Road Safety <i>(in German)</i>	Tier 2	Feb 2026	The German Mobility Data Space and the European Data for Road Safety consortium, comprising more than thirty industry partners including BMW with eight million connected vehicles, Mercedes-Benz, Skoda and HERE Technologies alongside road authorities, have agreed to exchange safety-related traffic information detected by connected vehicle sensors, covering wrong-way drivers, adverse weather, roadworks and reduced visibility, in near real time through a decentralised sovereign data infrastructure governed by a multi-party contract and routed onward via national access points.
Highways News	Tier 3	May 2026	Darren Capes, the Department for Transport's Head of Road Infrastructure Technology, set out a Connected Vehicle Services programme under which transport data would be made available to all service providers through open standards, covering infrastructure-to-vehicle and vehicle-to-infrastructure communication and the translation of road regulations into vehicle-readable form, with departmental consultation continuing through summer 2026.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Highways Magazine	Tier 3	Mar 2026	The programme organises connected vehicle services into seven use case groups covering safety and emergency, traffic management, advanced vehicle capabilities, in-vehicle experience, vehicle management and maintenance, support for authorities, and fleet and logistics, with officials saying they will soon be able to talk about funding and pilots, and with the Manual for Smart Streets to be rewritten as the digital-services equivalent of the Design Manual for Roads and Bridges.
Garrigues	Tier 3	Nov 2025	Analysing the Commission guidance accompanying the Data Act, the firm sets out that users have a right of free access to data generated by their connected vehicle and may designate third parties to receive it, that manufacturers must provide access directly where technically feasible or otherwise to readily available data without disproportionate effort, that third-party access runs on fair, reasonable and non-discriminatory terms with possible compensation, that shared data must match the quality the manufacturer holds, and that inferred data such as driving style scores falls outside the regime.
Highways News	Tier 3	Oct 2025	At the LCRIG Strictly Highways event the department opened a public and private sector conversation on a digital vehicle services programme covering future connected data services linking vehicles, road users and road operators, intended to be reflected in the Transport Data Action Plan and the Integrated National Transport Strategy and to incorporate European vehicle and data standards.

Theme 4: Cyber and positioning obligations set outside the programme

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
HM Treasury	Tier 1	Jul 2026	Electric vehicle excise duty will take effect from April 2028 and at each renewal registered keepers will be required to provide an up-to-date mileage reading and estimate their mileage for the year ahead, with optional additional functionality allowing motorists to choose to use their vehicle's in-built connectivity for a quicker system, and a planned legal requirement for a vehicle to have a functioning odometer together with offences for tampering and for supplying or installing tampering devices.
House of Commons Library	Tier 1	May 2026	Transport is already one of the sectors regulated under the Network and Information Systems Regulations 2018, each with a designated competent authority responsible for guidance, monitoring and enforcement, and the Bill extends that regime to data centres, large load controllers, managed service providers and critical suppliers to regulated organisations while requiring regulated organisations to report more cyber incidents.
Liikenne- ja viestintävirasto Traficom (Finnish Transport and Communications Agency)	Tier 1	Apr 2026	The agency reports that satellite navigation and mobile network interference increased during spring 2026, that interference observations in its own frequency monitoring rose clearly from February 2026, that interference is observed particularly in aviation around the clock across southern and central Finland, that at ground level the interference situation is normal so disruption does not as a rule occur although it remains locally possible near the eastern border, and that Finnish mobile networks have their own assured synchronisation arrangements which satellite timing only supplements.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
NIS Cooperation Group, with the European Commission and ENISA	Tier 1	Jan 2026	The assessment finds that attacks on vehicle control and processing systems are linked to severe consequences including loss of life, identifies as a top risk a hostile third country pressuring a manufacturer to implement hidden malicious hardware or software, notes that high-risk suppliers can use known and hidden direct access pathways to bypass many controls, documents satellite navigation spoofing among researched attack methods, and recommends that member states establish a common basis for assessing critical suppliers and put national policies in place to restrict or exclude high-risk suppliers.
National Cyber Security Centre	Tier 1	Jan 2026	The centre published eight secure connectivity principles for operational technology co-produced with partner agencies in Australia, Canada, the United States, Germany, the Netherlands and New Zealand, covering balancing risk and opportunity, limiting connectivity exposure, centralising and standardising network connections, using standardised and secure protocols, hardening the boundary, limiting the impact of compromise, logging and monitoring all connectivity, and establishing an isolation plan, on the basis that in these environments an intrusion can lead to physical harm or disruption of an operator of essential services.
Department for Science, Innovation and Technology (GOV.UK)	Tier 1	Nov 2025	The government announced 155 million pounds for positioning, navigation and timing resilience, comprising 71 million to begin a UK enhanced long-range navigation programme providing coverage across land, air and sea independent of satellite signals and hard to jam or spoof, 68 million for further development of the National Timing Centre delivered by the National Physical Laboratory, and 13 million for a satellite navigation interference monitoring programme.

Source	Tier	Date	Key claim used
Vehicle Certification Agency (Department for Transport)	Tier 1	Nov 2025	Statutory Instrument 2025 No. 1110 brings UN Regulation 155 on cyber security and UN Regulation 156 on software updating into the GB type approval scheme, entering into force on 13 November 2025, with the first mandatory implementation date for new types of complete and base vehicles set at 1 June 2026 and multistage and special purpose vehicles following in subsequent years, and manufacturers already holding those approvals for other markets able to add them to existing GB approvals through revision ahead of the mandatory dates.
UK Parliament, House of Lords (Hansard)	Tier 1	Oct 2025	Ministers told the House that the government had published a written statement guaranteeing the company 1.5 billion pounds so that it had sufficient cash reserves to pay its supply chain creditors, that the National Cyber Security Centre had been working closely with the company and would take part in a cross-government lessons identified process, and that the Cyber Security and Resilience Bill would be introduced to raise standards in critical and essential services.
United Nations Economic Commission for Europe, via the Official Journal of the European Union	Tier 1	Jan 2025	UN Regulation 155 applies to vehicles fitted with at least one electronic control unit and requires the manufacturer to hold a certificate of compliance for a cyber security management system, valid for a maximum of three years, covering development, production and post-production, with risk assessment against the listed threats, proportionate mitigations, pre-approval security testing, post-registration monitoring for threats and vulnerabilities, and annual reporting of monitoring outcomes to the approval authority.

Claim-fidelity self-disclosure

This briefing rests on 35 sources, every one opened and read rather than taken from a search result. 31 are in English, two in Dutch and one each in German and Finnish. Eleven spans are quoted word for word; the rest are summarised. Twenty-two are Tier 1 and none is Tier 4. Where we summarise, we have tried not to make a source say more than it says. This box records where that was hardest.

The central finding rests on an omission

The claim that the digital traffic order duty is uncommenced is drawn from what a statutory instrument does not contain ([SI 2025/1339](#), Dec 2025). That record is graded in the source file as an analyst inference rather than a faithful summary, because reading significance into an absence is a weaker move than quoting a presence. It is corroborated in the opposite direction by the service guidance, which sets out no duty, no commencement date and no deadline ([DfT](#), Sep 2025). If a later commencement order names section 93, this finding expires rather than being wrong.

One claim carried as direction and not magnitude

The proposition that most connected vehicle road data sits in private hands comes from a single trade source that offers no quantified public and private split ([Future Transport-News](#), Jun 2026). We use it for direction. Any figure a reader wants for the actual proportion is not in this briefing because we could not verify one.

Two gaps we could not close

There is no dated UK decision on spectrum or roadside infrastructure for connected vehicles inside the recency window at any tier. The European deployment figures ([the European Commission](#), Apr 2026) are therefore a benchmark, not a UK position, and the report says so where they appear. Separately, no authoritative dated account of a cyber incident against a UK local authority traffic control system could be verified, so the reference incident used is an automotive manufacturer ([Hansard](#), Oct 2025). That is adjacent to road operations rather than an example of them.

Sources read and then dropped

Four were dropped on the age rule rather than stretched. The AI Playbook for the UK Government, the department's roadmap to third-party assurance, a parliamentary library briefing on the section 93 duty and the Commission's own vehicle data guidance are all directly relevant and all fall outside twelve months without being legislation or a statistical series, so each was replaced by an in-window source carrying the same content rather than being relabelled as a structural anchor to

get it past the gate. One trade report of the connected vehicle programme speech returned a 403 and was discarded rather than cited on trust; two other outlets covering the same speech were verified and used instead.

Four themes, where the format carries five or six

This cycle runs four themes at the analyst's instruction, scoped to one post's remit rather than to a department. The structure audit flags that as a deviation and it is left flagged rather than padded to five, because a fifth theme added to satisfy a count would be the weakest thing in the briefing. The same audit notes the absence of a continuity ledger, which is correct and expected: this is the first edition of a new series and there is no prior cycle to grade.

A rule that primary legislation cannot satisfy

Three instruments are carried as structural anchors: the Automated Vehicles Act, the first commencement order under it, and the UN vehicle cyber security regulation ([the Automated Vehicles Act 2024](#), May 2024) ([SI 2025/1339](#), Dec 2025) ([UN Regulation 155](#), Jan 2025). The sourcing guide says a structural anchor should not be more than twelve months old, which primary legislation almost never is, so the date audit warns that the Act is 851 days old. The warning is not suppressed. It is a conflict in the rule rather than a defect in the source, and it is recorded here as it was in the companion briefing, so the question is inherited rather than the workaround.

Dates recorded to the month

Six documents print only a month and year. In each the first of that month is recorded and the absence of a day is noted in the source record, rather than a day being inferred from a web address.

Relationship to the companion briefing

The department-wide cycle published on 17 September covers road transport as one of five themes and declared an evidence gap on connected vehicle standards, which this cycle closes ([Highways Magazine](#), Mar 2026) ([Highways News](#), May 2026). Where the two overlap, this briefing cites its own sources rather than the earlier report, and it does not grade itself against that cycle's readings, because the audience and the scope are different and a continuity ledger between them would be a false comparison.

This Decision Intelligence briefing is the quarterly synthesis of a Shaping Tomorrow intelligence cycle on the **DfT Road Transport Group**. It sits on top of weekly Signal Scans that identify emerging developments and weak signals, and monthly Change Trackers that assess what is materially shifting in momentum. Cycles may also close with Action Triggers, an end-of-cycle

synthesis that reads across all four formats and surfaces patterns no single deliverable carries on its own. Continuous intelligence on this topic is available as a Single-Topic or Multi-Topic programme.

[Discuss a Tailored Programme](#)

Prepared by Shaping Tomorrow: 18 September 2026